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The AI Agent Bootcamp for Small Business

Module 1: AI Agents vs. Chatbots

Understand what AI agents actually are, what they can and can't do, and choose a starter toolkit that fits your budget.

FREE SAMPLE

About this module

This is **Module 1: AI Agents vs. Chatbots** from **The AI Agent Bootcamp for Small Business**, a hands-on course that teaches you to use AI agents to build, sell and automate, one step-by-step project at a time. This module is a **free sample**.

How this module works

- 1 **Goal:** what you'll be able to do by the end.
- 2 **Plain-English concepts:** the ideas, with no jargon left unexplained.
- 3 **Step-by-step instructions:** numbered steps you can follow with this PDF open next to you.
- 4 **Checkpoint:** "You should now see...", so you know it worked before moving on.
- 5 **If you get stuck:** the most common snags and how to get past them.
- 6 **Recap:** a short checklist of what you did.

At the end you'll find a **module toolkit** with prompts, key terms and quick fixes for this module.

Platforms, not models, and no lock-in

AI tools change fast, so this course names platforms (like ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Cursor or GitHub) but not specific model versions; when it matters, it says something like *"switch to your assistant's strongest model."* Purple **"What I use"** boxes show the tools used at Cody J Web Studio alongside good alternatives. Steps describe what to look for rather than exact menus, and link to each platform's official docs. Prices and free tiers change, so always **check current pricing**.

Disclaimer

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01

MODULE

AI Agents vs. Chatbots

Goal: Understand what AI agents actually are, what they can and can't do, and choose a starter toolkit that fits your budget.

IN THIS MODULE

- Quick win: build a working web page in 5 minutes
- The difference between a chatbot, an assistant and an agent
- What agents are great at, and where they fail
- Tools, connectors, and scheduled routines explained
- How to pick tools and when paying is worth it
- Your first real agent task

TIME

45 to 60 minutes

YOU'LL NEED

A browser and an email address

YOU'LL WALK AWAY WITH

A free AI assistant account, a chosen coding tool, and a clear picture of where agents fit in your work

Quick win: a working web page in 5 minutes

Before any theory, let's see what AI can actually do. You're going to build an interactive web page for your business with one prompt. No coding, no installs.

- 1 **Open an AI assistant.** If you don't have one yet, create a free account with ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Grok or Microsoft Copilot. It takes two minutes.
- 2 **Paste this prompt** and fill in the brackets:

Create a complete, single-file web page (HTML, with the CSS and JavaScript inside the same file) for my business: [business name], a [what you do] in [city/area].

Include: a bold headline and short subheadline, three service cards, a "Get a quote" button, and an interactive "instant estimate" tool where a visitor picks a service and a size (small / medium / large) and immediately sees an estimated price range. Use obviously fake example prices for now; I'll replace them later.

Make it modern, mobile-friendly and attractive. Give me the full code in one block.

- 1 **See it live.** Many assistants show a live preview right in the chat (look for a *preview*, *canvas* or *artifact* panel). If yours doesn't:
 - Copy the code. Open a plain-text editor (**Notepad** on Windows; on a Mac, **TextEdit** switched to plain text in its Format menu).
 - Paste, then save the file as `my-first-page.html` in your Bootcamp folder.
 - Double-click the file. It opens in your browser.
- 2 **Try the estimate tool.** Pick a service and a size. The price updates instantly. That's JavaScript, written for you.
- 3 **Change it with one sentence.** Reply: "Switch to a dark theme with orange accents and add a 3-question FAQ at the bottom." Then refresh or re-save and look again.

Checkpoint

You should now see a styled web page with your business name and a working estimate calculator, created from a couple of sentences. Keep `my-first-page.html` : you'll look under its hood in Module 4 (sold separately or in the full bundle), and in Module 5 (sold separately or in the full bundle) you'll build a polished, *live* website the professional way.

If you get stuck

"It gave me instructions instead of code." Reply: *"Please give me the complete code for the file in a single code block."*

"The file opens as text, not a web page." It was saved as `.txt` or rich text. Make sure the name ends in `.html` and the editor is in plain-text mode.

"Part of the code is missing." Long answers sometimes get cut off. Reply: *"Continue exactly where you stopped,"* or ask for a shorter version.

That's the shift this bootcamp is about: you described an outcome, and AI produced a working thing. Now let's understand what's going on, so you can do this reliably for real work.

Chatbot, assistant, agent: what's the difference?

These words get thrown around loosely, so let's pin them down. Think of them as a ladder. Each rung can do everything the rung below can, plus more.

The ladder

Chatbot: You type, it replies. It only knows what was in its training plus what you paste in. It can't *do* anything outside the chat window.

Assistant: A chatbot with extras. It might search the web, read files you upload, remember preferences, or create documents and images. You still drive every step.

Agent: An assistant that can **take actions toward a goal over multiple steps**, using tools. You give it a task ("research five competitors and put the findings in a spreadsheet"), and it plans, uses tools (browser, files, code, connected apps), checks its own progress and reports back. You supervise instead of doing every step.

Chatbot

Answers questions from what it already knows. Can't act outside the chat.

Assistant

Adds web search, files, memory and document creation. You drive every step.

Agent

Plans and takes multi-step actions with tools and connected apps. You supervise and approve.

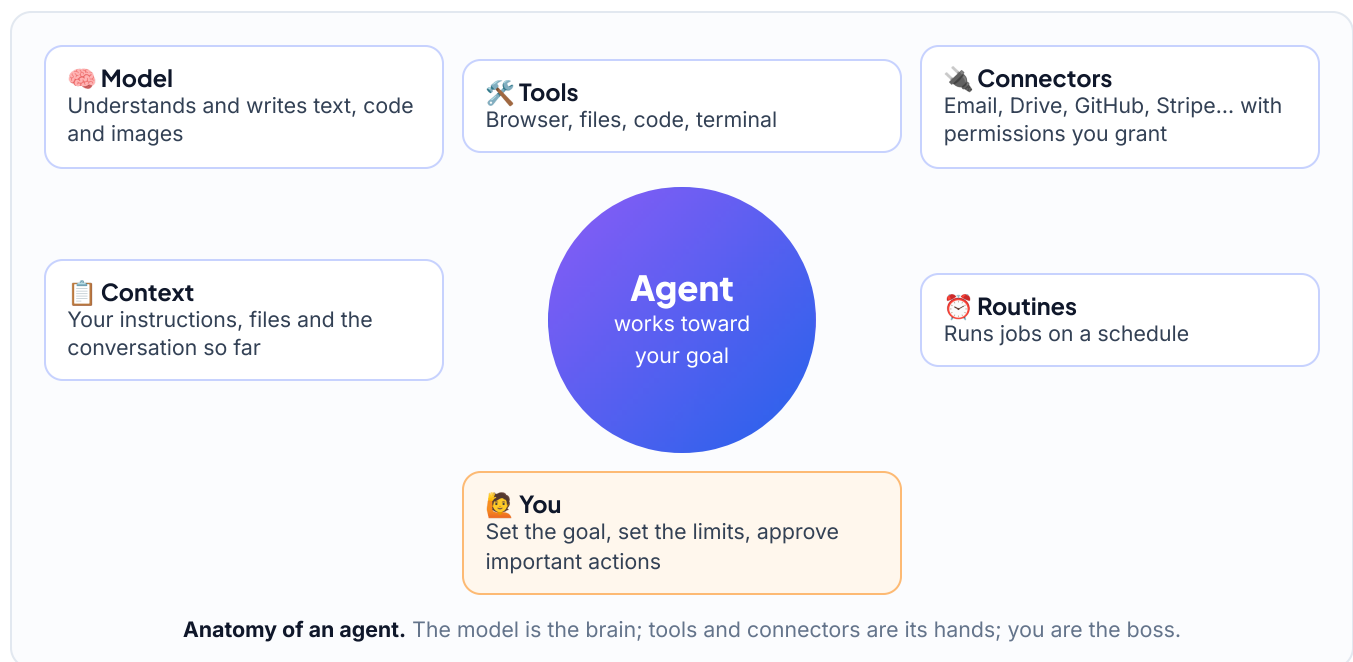
The AI ladder. Each rung can do everything below it, plus more.

The key shift is from **answers** to **outcomes**. A chatbot tells you how to make a spreadsheet. An agent makes the spreadsheet.

The building blocks that make an agent

You'll see these terms in every agent product, whatever the brand:

- **Model:** the "brain" that understands and writes text (and often images or code). Platforms let you pick between models; stronger ones are slower or cost more but handle harder tasks.
- **Tools:** abilities the agent can use, such as browsing the web, running code, reading and writing files, or using a terminal.
- **Connectors (also called integrations, apps, or MCP servers):** secure links to your other accounts, such as email, calendar, Google Drive, GitHub or Stripe. A connector lets the agent read or act in that app *with the permissions you grant*.
- **Memory / context:** what the agent knows about the current task: your instructions, files, earlier messages and anything it looked up.
- **Routines (scheduled tasks):** jobs an agent runs on a schedule without you starting them, like "every Monday at 8 a.m., summarize last week's sales and email me the draft."
- **Human-in-the-loop:** points where the agent stops and asks you to approve something before it acts (for example, before sending an email or merging code). Good agents make this easy; you should insist on it for anything important.



What "MCP" means

You'll often see **MCP (Model Context Protocol)** mentioned. It's an open standard for connecting AI tools to other apps and data. You don't need to understand the technical details. Just know that "this tool supports MCP" usually means "you can connect it to more of your apps."

What agents are great at (and where they fail)

Being honest about limits is what separates people who get results from people who get burned.

Agents are great at

- First drafts of almost anything: emails, pages, posts, outlines, code
- Research and summarizing lots of material quickly
- Repetitive multi-step chores (rename, reformat, compile, compare)
- Writing and fixing website code from plain-English requests
- Turning messy notes into clean documents, tables and checklists
- Explaining things patiently, as many times as you need

Agents struggle with

- **Facts they can't check:** they can state wrong things confidently (called "hallucinating")
- Very recent events, unless they can search the web
- Knowing your business, customers and voice, unless you tell them
- Judgment calls with legal, financial or safety consequences
- Long tasks with vague goals: they drift without clear checkpoints
- Anything requiring access you haven't granted, which is a good thing

The golden rule

You are the editor-in-chief. AI produces drafts; you approve what ships. Anything that goes to a customer, touches money, gets published, or changes live code gets a human review first. Module 3 (sold separately or in the full bundle) shows you how to build that habit.

Picking your tools

You need two kinds of tool for this bootcamp, and possibly a third:

- 1 **A general AI assistant or agent** for research, writing, planning and business tasks.
- 2 **An AI coding tool** for building and editing your website.
- 3 *(Later)* **An automation platform** for workflows that run on their own (Module 8, sold separately or in the full bundle).

What I use (and alternatives)

General agent: I use a desktop AI agent app that can run multi-step tasks, use connectors to my accounts (like GitHub, Stripe and Cloudflare) and run scheduled routines. **Alternatives:** ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Grok and Microsoft Copilot all offer capable assistants, and most now offer some mix of web search, file handling, connectors, agent modes and scheduled tasks. Features vary by plan.

AI coding: I use **Cursor**, an AI code editor, including its **cloud agents** that work on a task in the background and open a pull request for me to review. **Alternatives:** GitHub Copilot, Windsurf, Claude Code and OpenAI Codex (code-focused agents and editors), or browser-based builders like Replit, Bolt and Lovable that are very beginner-friendly.

How to choose: five questions

- 1 **Where do you already work?** If your business runs on Google Workspace, an assistant with good Google connectors saves time. If you live in Microsoft 365, look at Copilot or assistants with Microsoft connectors.
- 2 **Do you want to see the code?** Code editors (Cursor, Windsurf, VS Code with Copilot) show you every file, which is best for learning and control. Browser builders (Replit, Bolt, Lovable) hide more of it, which is faster to start but harder to move elsewhere later.
- 3 **Can it connect to what you need?** Check the connectors or integrations list for the apps you use daily.
- 4 **Does it let you approve actions?** Look for settings that ask before sending, deleting, purchasing or merging.
- 5 **What does the free tier allow?** Free tiers usually limit how much you can use the strongest models, how many agent tasks you can run, or which features you get.

Free vs. paid: when to upgrade

Start free. Upgrade **one** tool when you notice you're regularly hitting limits on something that's saving you real time. A common path:

- **Weeks 1 to 2:** free tiers of everything while you learn.
- **When you start building seriously:** a paid plan on *either* your general assistant *or* your coding tool, whichever you use more.
- **When it's earning its keep:** add the second.

Always **check current pricing**. Plans change frequently, and many tools offer monthly billing you can cancel.

Use the strongest model for hard tasks

Most platforms let you pick a model or a "mode." Use a fast model for quick, simple jobs. Switch to your assistant's **strongest model** (sometimes labeled as a reasoning, thinking or pro model) for planning, debugging, and anything where accuracy matters.

Step by step: set up your AI workspace

- 1 **Create (or sign in to) a general AI assistant account.** Pick one from the list above. Use an email you'll keep for business.
- 2 **Turn on two-factor authentication (2FA)** in the account's security settings. Your AI account will soon be connected to other accounts, so protect it like your email.
- 3 **Review the privacy and data settings.** Look for options about whether your chats can be used to train models, chat history, and memory. Choose what you're comfortable with (Module 3 covers this in depth).
- 4 **Add "custom instructions" or a profile**, if your assistant supports it. This is a short note the assistant reads before every chat. Use the template below.

- 5 **Install or open your AI coding tool** (an app where AI writes and edits website code with you). If you're using a code editor like Cursor or Windsurf, download it from the official site. If you prefer a browser builder (Replit, Bolt, Lovable), just create an account. You'll use it in Module 5.
- 6 **Create a free GitHub account** at github.com and turn on 2FA. You'll need it in Modules 4 and 5.
- 7 **Make a "Bootcamp" folder** on your computer and a matching folder in your cloud drive (Google Drive or OneDrive). Save your work here as you go.

Custom instructions template (edit the brackets):

About me: I run [business type] in [city/state, or "nationwide, US"]. My customers are [who]. I'm a beginner with code but comfortable with [tools you use].

How to respond: Use plain US English. Be concise; use bullet points and numbered steps. When you're unsure or a fact could be outdated, say so clearly and tell me how to verify it. Never invent statistics, quotes, or reviews. Ask me a clarifying question if my request is ambiguous.

My brand voice: [friendly / professional / playful], [any words to avoid].

Your first real agent task

Let's feel the difference between chatting and delegating. Give your assistant a small, real, multi-step task, ideally one that uses web search or files.

- 1 Open a new chat. If your assistant has an agent, research, or web-search mode, turn it on.
- 2 Paste this prompt, filling in your details:

I run [business type] in [location]. Research 3 local or online competitors that serve similar customers. For each, find: website URL, the main services they promote, how they ask for contact (form, phone, booking), and one thing their website does well.

Put the results in a table. Then give me 3 specific ideas I could use on my own website. Include the source link for every fact, and mark anything you couldn't verify as "unverified".

- 1 Watch what it does. Agent-style tools will show steps like "searching..." or "opening page...".
- 2 **Click at least two of the source links** and confirm the facts match. This is the habit that keeps you safe.

Checkpoint

You should now see a table of three competitors with source links, plus three ideas. If you clicked the links, you've probably already found one detail the AI got slightly wrong or out of date. **That's normal, and noticing it is the skill.**

If you get stuck

"It says it can't browse the web." Your current mode or plan may not include web search. Look for a search, research or tools toggle, or try another assistant. You can also paste in text from competitor sites yourself.

"The links don't work or go to the wrong page." The AI may have guessed the URL. Ask: *"Re-check each link and only include ones you actually opened."* Then verify manually.

"The answer is generic." Add more context: your exact location, your customer type, and what you want to learn. Module 2 (sold separately or in the full bundle) is all about this.

Recap

- ☐ I can explain the difference between a chatbot, an assistant and an agent.
- ☐ I know what tools, connectors and routines are.
- ☐ I have an AI assistant account with 2FA and privacy settings reviewed.
- ☐ I've picked an AI coding tool for Module 5 and created a GitHub account.
- ☐ I ran my first multi-step research task **and checked its sources**.

Prompts for this module

Copy-paste starting points for this module. Replace everything in [brackets] and review the output before you use it.

1. Set up custom instructions

Help me write custom instructions for my AI assistant. About me: [business, location, customers, skill level]. I want answers that are [concise/detailed], in plain US English, with numbered steps for tasks. Include rules: say when unsure, never invent stats/quotes/reviews, ask clarifying questions when needed. Keep it under 150 words.

2. Explain it simply

Explain [concept] to me like I'm a smart beginner with no technical background. Use one everyday analogy, then a concrete example from a small business like mine ([business type]). Finish with 3 quick questions to check my understanding.

3. Break a big goal into steps

My goal: [goal] by [date]. I have about [X] hours per week. Break this into weekly milestones and daily tasks under 1 hour each. Flag which tasks AI can help with and which need me.

4. Decision helper

I'm deciding between [option A] and [option B] for [purpose]. My priorities, in order: [1, 2, 3]. Compare them in a table against my priorities, list the risks of each, and tell me what information would change your recommendation.

5. Interview me first

I want to create [deliverable]. Before writing anything, interview me with up to 8 questions, one or two at a time, to gather what you need. Then summarize my answers and confirm before you write.

Key terms & quick fixes

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Agent (AI agent)	An AI that takes actions toward a goal over multiple steps, using tools like a browser, files, code or connected apps.
Connector	A link that lets an AI assistant access another app (email, drive, GitHub) with permissions you grant. Also called integration or app.
Context	The information an AI has for the current task: your instructions, files and the conversation.
Custom instructions	Standing notes an assistant reads before every chat (your role, preferences, rules).
Hallucination	When AI states something false or made up as if it were true.
Human-in-the-loop	A design where a person reviews or approves before an AI's action takes effect.
MCP (Model Context Protocol)	An open standard for connecting AI tools to apps and data sources.
Model	The AI "brain" that generates text, code or images. Platforms offer several; stronger ones handle harder tasks.
Prompt	The instructions you give an AI.
Routine / scheduled task	An AI or automation job that runs automatically on a schedule.

Quick fixes

AI assistants and agents

The AI gave me wrong information. Normal; it happens. Ask for sources, verify specifics on official sites, and use a tool with web search for factual work. Never publish unverified stats, quotes or legal claims.

Output is generic or bland. Add context (Business Brain), examples of what you like, constraints, and ask it to interview you first. Use your assistant's strongest model for important work.

It ignores part of my prompt. Split the task into smaller prompts, put critical rules in a short "Rules" list at the end, and start a fresh chat if the conversation is long.

I hit a usage limit. Free tiers cap usage. Wait for the reset, switch to a lighter model for simple tasks, or consider upgrading the one tool you use most (check current pricing).

The agent did something I didn't want. Undo it (Git history, version history in Docs/Sheets, trash). Tighten boundaries in your prompt and turn on approval prompts for risky actions. For coding agents, use branches and pull requests so nothing goes live without review.

A connector won't connect or lost access. Disconnect and reconnect it, check you granted the right permissions, and confirm you're signed in to the right account. Some connectors need re-authorization periodically.

The universal fix

"I'm trying to [goal]. I did [steps]. I expected [result], but I got [what happened, with the exact error message]. I'm using [tool/platform]. What are the most likely causes, from most to least likely, and how do I check each one? Point me to the official docs."

WHAT'S IN THE FULL BUNDLE

Get all of The AI Agent Bootcamp for Small Business

Every module, every appendix, and every starter file in one download.

\$19 for all 10 modules + appendices + starter files

All 10 modules

✓ **Module 1: AI Agents vs. Chatbots** **YOU HAVE THIS**

✓ Module 2: Prompting That Works

✓ Module 3: Safety & Security Basics

✓ Module 4: Web Dev Basics for Non-Coders

✓ Module 5: Project 1: Build & Publish Your Website

✓ Module 6: Project 2: Contact Methods & Basic SEO

✓ Module 7: Project 3: Sell a Digital Product

✓ Module 8: Project 4: Automations That Run Themselves

✓ Module 9: Project 5: AI Agents for Business Ops

✓ Module 10: Making Money With These Skills

Appendices & toolkit

- A library of 50 copy-paste prompts, grouped by task
- A plain-English glossary
- Tool comparison tables (free tiers, best for, alternatives)
- A full troubleshooting FAQ
- A day-by-day 30-day action plan
- A directory of official docs

Starter files

- One-page website template (`index.html` + `styles.css`)
- Payment-checked download page template (Cloudflare Worker), with setup guide and offline test
- The prompt library as a copy-paste-friendly file
- A 30-day plan & progress tracker spreadsheet (.xlsx)

Save with the bundle

Modules 2 to 10 are **\$5 each** (Module 1 is free), so buying them one at a time adds up to **\$45**. The full bundle is **\$19**, and it also includes all the appendices and starter files.

Get the full bundle or any module at cjcodey.github.io/codyjwebstudio, or message Cody J Web Studio on WhatsApp: wa.me/447378776848.

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